The Middle East Journal

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Source: *Middle East Journal*, Summer, 1987, Vol. 41, No. 3 (Summer, 1987), pp. 361-378

Published by: Middle East Institute

Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/4327585

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INTERNAL CONTRADICTIONS IN THE PFLP: DECISION MAKING AND POLICY ORIENTATION

As'ad AbuKhalil

The study of non-state actors is a difficult task. In the first place, they do not fit within the confines of nation-state characteristics and do not operate in an open system according to well-defined laws and regulations. "The behavior of non-state nations in international politics may appear baffling, quixotic, and annoying when viewed from the perspective of nation-states, especially the big powers."[1] Secondly, many of them operate clandestinely and reliable information about them is hard to come by. The Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (henceforth, the PFLP) is a case in point; it has been operating underground and in the open.

What makes the study of self-proclaimed revolutionary groups in the Arab East peculiarly difficult is that they discourage scholarly interest in their organizations. Given the permanent security threat posed by its various opponents, including Israel, the PFLP rarely offers information that goes beyond the official propaganda line and trying to get more can be dangerous. A West German journalist, Robert Pfeffer, was assassinated in Beirut while preparing a comprehensive study of the late Wadi' Haddad[2] and there does not exist today a single scholarly, or even serious journalistic, work on the PFLP. The only sources that have touched upon the subject have been books on "international terrorism," which very often contain false and misleading information.

1. Bertelsen, Judy, ed., *Non-State Nations in International Politics: Comparative System Analyses*, (New York: Praeger, 1977), p. 256.
2. Becker, Jillian, *The PLO*, (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1984, p. 159. It should be noted that this book contains several errors and fallacies.

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This paper is an attempt to look more deeply into the PFLP and to go beyond the official publications of that organization. The information given below comes from interviews with numerous members of the PFLP, including George Habash and other Politburo and Central Committee members, conducted by the author between 1978 and 1984 as part of a research project on the Palestinian and Lebanese left. The interviews are supplemented by readings in the literature of the Front, and particularly from the party mouthpiece, *al-Hadaf*. For obvious reasons, sources other than those published cannot be quoted.

ORIGINS OF THE PFLP

The PFLP developed within the womb, so to speak, of the Harakat al-Qawmiyyin al-'Arab (the Arab Nationalist Movement, henceforth, the ANM). It was officially born on 11 December 1967 as a result of the merger of three formerly independent groups. Two of these—the Heroes of Return and the National Front for the Liberation of Palestine (also known as the Organization of the Youth of Revenge), were connected with the ANM. The third group was the Palestine Liberation Front, a small guerrilla organization created in 1959 by Ahmad Jibril and disbanded in 1967 (not to be confused with the present-day Palestinian Liberation Front, which split off from the PFLP-General Command in 1977). The birth of the PFLP was connected to the state of despair resulting from the Arab defeat in the June war of 1967, and also to the intense schismatic tensions within the organizational body of the ANM. George Habash headed at the time what was known as the "rightest faction" of the ANM, while Nayif Hawatmah and Muhsin Ibrahim were associated with the "leftist faction." The distinctive ideological underpinning of the PFLP was symbolized by a firm insistence on the efficacy of the "path of armed struggle" for the goal of liberating Palestine, and also by an outright rejection of all compromise solutions for the Palestine question.[3]

The PFLP proceeded to transform the former cells of the ANM into a new Marxist-Leninist organization, which has aspired to be the vanguard party of the "Palestinian working class," but notwithstanding its rhetoric, the PFLP diverged little from the ideological inheritance and social composition of the ANM. It soon became the second most important Palestinian organization (the first being Fatḥ) in terms of military capability and political significance. It has always constituted a threat to the mainstream Palestinian position concerning the solution of the Palestinian question; being identified with the Rejectionist Front of the seventies,

3. On the early history of the PFLP, see Riad al-Rayyes and Dunia Nahas, *Guerrillas for Palestine*, (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1976), pp. 36–44; and the entry on the PFLP in the second volume of *al-Mawsu'ah al-Filastiniyyah* (The Palestinian Encyclopedia), translated and reprinted in *Democratic Palestine*, No. 13, January 1986.

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the PFLP represented the PLO opposition to Arafat. As difficult as it is to determine the exact size of the fighting force of the organization, the PFLP is believed to be capable of mustering more than five thousand armed men.[4]

THE IDIOSYNCRASIES OF "AL-HAKIM"

The personality cult is a phenomenon that dominates most of the political parties of the Arab East. Among these parties, there generally emerges a leader who tends to play a key role in decision making. The leader is usually referred to by a special title which adds to his glorification and idolization by the party members. In other words, every party has its own hero who is essential to its claim to political legitimacy. In many cases, the charisma of the hero-idol serves as a major tool of party recruitment. The PFLP is no exception. In fact, it represents an extreme case of personality cult, given the enormous charisma and popularity that have surrounded the personality and leadership of George Habash. He is referred to by his supporters as *al-Hakim,* which denotes both the physician and the wise man.

Habash's strong leadership dominated the politics of the old Arab Nationalist Movement, of which he was a founder, and of the PFLP (especially prior to 1980, the year Habash had a massive stroke that weakened his physical and intellectual abilities). To say, however, that his views constitute a major determinant is not to maintain that this factor alone can explain the decision making process within the PFLP. His influential role has to be studied within a larger context that includes the organizational mechanism of the party as well as the political arena within which it operates. Within the ANM, nevertheless, loyalties were often expressed in terms of personal support for certain figures within the leadership and one should not be misled by propaganda claims regarding the ostensibly decisive role of ideology. Habash's leadership has always been assertive, authoritarian, and credible (in the eyes of his audience because of his long history as a political activist). It has not always been harmonious, however. His role in the ANM, for instance, antagonized several leading members, who accused him of resorting to fascistic methods and procedures,[5] and his personal rivalry with Nayif Hawatmah shattered the Movement's precarious organizational unity.[6]

Similarly, the personality factor dominates internal organizational structures, as well as key policy formulations of the PFLP. Although Habash has maintained

4. For a general and accurate account of the PFLP's historical evolution, see Helena Cobban's *The Palestine Liberation Organization: People, Power and Politics,* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1984), pp. 140–152.

5. See Muhsin Ibrahim's *Limadha Munadhdhamat al-Ishtirakiyyin al-Lubnaniyyin* (Why the Organization of Lebanese Socialists?), Beirut: Dar al-Taliah, 1970; and Kazziha, Walid, *Revolutionary Transformation in the Arab World,* (London: Knight, 1975), p. 100.

6. Kazziha, *op.cit.*

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the unity and discipline of the organization, he himself caused a series of defections from the Front by people who objected to his organizational dominance, or who were jealous of his charisma and appeal. While Habash was in prison in Syria in 1968, factionalism and intense rivalry were tearing the Front apart. It was during his absence that two major defections from the PFLP were prepared. Ahmad Jibril split from the Front in 1968 to form his own organization, the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine—General Command, while Nayif Hawatmah waited until early 1969 to declare the formation of the Democratic (originally Democratic-Popular) Front for the Liberation of Palestine.

Following these defections, along with the defections of the Popular (Revolutionary) Front for the Liberation of Palestine under the leadership of Walid Qaddurah, whose connections to Lebanese security services were suspected but never proven, the PFLP was left with members fanatically loyal to Habash's supreme leadership. As secretary-general, al-Hakim presides over the meetings of the Politburo, the Central Committee, and the National Congress. He usually resolves conflicts and differences between the leading members and factions by stating his decisive position, which becomes the official party line. According to the internal rules of the Front, all members are supposed to adhere to decisions reached by the leading bodies once they are propagated through party channels.[7] Thus, it becomes essential to focus on Habash in order to grasp the actual decision making process of the Front, bearing in mind that his 1980 stroke diminished markedly his ability to exercise supreme control.

One source of Habash's appeal is that his political views have undergone few changes over the years, notwithstanding the recent shifts of PFLP policy orientations which have coincided with the diminution in his power. Until the last party Congress of 1981, he was consistent in his position towards the solution of the Palestine question, and always represented the extremist trend within the Palestinian resistance movement. He has always insisted on a total liberation of Palestine, even after a consensus started to develop within the movement around a two-state solution in 1974. Although his stance should theoretically be based upon a firm belief in a secular solution, the PFLP has often expressed anti-Jewish sentiments. Such sentiments motivated Habash as a young student when he bombed the Beirut synagogue, and the ANM was quite explicit in its anti-Jewish position. It perceived Zionism as an ideology synonymous with Judaism.[8] Although this position was expected to change with the dissolution of the ANM after the 1967 defeat and its transformation into Marxist-Leninist parties around the Arab world, the adoption of atheist and secular thought did not erode the anti-Jewish attitudes of the PFLP. Habash himself has expressed explicit anti-

7. See the PFLP, *al-Nidham al-Dakhili* (The Internal Rules), Articles 10, 11, 12 and 13.
8. Matar, Fu'ad, ed., *Hakim al-Thawrah* (The Wise Man of the Revolution), London: Highlight, 1984, p. 74.

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Jewish sentiments in published interviews. In one interview with *Life* magazine he indicated that the PFLP intended to kill as many Jews as it could, including Jews living away "from the battleground."[9]

Habash is also known to be a staunch Arab nationalist and his chauvinism has hindered the Front's practicing an internationalist ideology. The branches of the former ANM found it very hard to cope with the new internationalist slogans and ideas of the late sixties. Their nationalist convictions were too strong to be overcome by one Leninist stroke. After all, nationalism, not internationalist brotherhood, is what inflames popular emotions. Thus, in a 1985 speech Habash told his audience that he always speaks and thinks as "an Arab nationalist"[10] and the literature of the Front is still full of emotional insistence on the primacy of Arab unity and Arab nationalism. The Arab nationalist element is not the only proof that the legacy of the ANM is well-preserved by the PFLP. The Nasserite version of Arab nationalism, which was dismissed in 1967 as typical petit-bourgeois, is now highly praised by Habash, who gives Nasser credit for his efforts to achieve Arab unity and the liberation of Palestine.[11] Paradoxically, Habash's strong belief in Arab nationalism has clashed with the narrower Palestinian chauvinism practiced by all PLO organizations in Jordan and Lebanon.[12]

Hasbash has been accustomed to an elitist approach to "revolutionary" organization and action. The group of students at the American University of Beirut who were to found the ANM believed in the vanguard role of intellectuals, and they laid an emphasis on achieving an educational, technological and military parity with Israel. This tendency to confine the leadership role to the intellectuals, who usually come from middle class origins, contradicts the ideological goal of seeking a proletarian leadership for the PFLP, a goal that in theory marked the transformation from a petit-bourgeois party (the ANM) into a would-be proletarian party (the PFLP).[13] In practice, the socio-economic composition of the PFLP leadership is far from being proletarian. Important leaders, like Bassam Abu Sharif, whose father is a manager of a major bank in Amman and who is married to a Maronite woman from a large landowning family, and to a lesser degree Habash and the late Wadi' Haddad (who after 1972 had his own organization named the PFLP-International Operations) have upper-middle class origins. This

9. *Life* magazine, June 12, 1970. The evidence for anti-Jewish sentiments in PFLP literature is quite abundant. *Al-Hadaf,* issue of June 30, 1986, for example, talks about the "wickedness of the Jews."

10. *Al-Hadaf,* April 8, 1985.

11. Matar, *op.cit.*, pp. 81–112.

12. The Front admits that it neglected the "progressive Jordanian movement." It considered the neglect a deadly error in the programs of the Resistance. See PFLP, *Tasks of the New Stage,* Beirut: PFLP Publications, 1972, p. 95.

13. See Habash's introduction to Arab Socialist Action Party, *Tariq al-Thawrah* (The Path of Revolution), September, 1970.

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has made the PFLP sensitive about carrying criticism of the petit-bourgeoisie too far.[14]

When the PFLP originally emerged in the late sixties, it relied upon its distinctive militant ideology and upon the political background of its leaders to attract members. In the early years, pictures of Habash appeared only rarely in the PFLP weekly mouthpiece *al-Hadaf* and the cult around Habash's personality began to assume wide dimensions only in the late seventies. In 1983, for example, more than twelve pictures of him appeared in one issue alone.[15] Habash, who used to shun publicity, became much more accessible to the press. His rallies increased, especially when other PFLP members expressed their resentment towards policies adopted by its leadership. But the power and authority of Habash did not stem only from his unique, charismatic qualities. It was only possible for him to enjoy such power because the organizational procedures of the party did not permit free expression. The Leninist doctrine of democratic centralism implies iron discipline. Within the PFLP, collective leadership has never been practiced, which has led to numerous defections and to factionalism among the higher and lower party levels. In 1984, for instance, Politburo member Abu al Ra'id (so code-named) resigned from his position in protest against what he considered dictatorial tendencies among some of the leading figures. The Front has continually faced organizational crises, but "strict party discipline"[16] has enabled the leadership to adopt policies and regulations even when they conflict with the desires and preferences of the members. Thus, many Party members were strongly opposed to reconciliation with the Syrian regime in 1977, as well as to the 1984 Aden Agreement (which was intended to reconcile the PFLP and the DFLP with Arafat). Even among the leadership there was strong opposition to both policies, but the party proceeded to implement them nevertheless.

In recent years, however, Habash has lost much of his energy and authority. Following his last massive stroke in 1980, and his subsequent long absence from the public scene, a new clique within the Party ruling elite has been successfully asserting itself. This has created a serious organizational crisis, since the new clique enjoys the support of the military element within the Party. According to one source, Habash wanted to install Abu Mahir al-Yamani as his successor in 1981,[17] but he failed to overcome the strong opposition from various Party leaders and members. Regardless of who the successor will be, it is highly unlikely that the PFLP will maintain even minimum unity and organizational cohesion after Habash's death. To members and supporters alike, the legitimacy and credibility of the Front have been closely associated with the personality of Habash.

14. See *al-Hadaf,* April 25, 1970.
15. *Al-Hadaf,* December 19, 1983.
16. *Al-Nidham al-Dakhili,* Article 11.
17. This information is based upon an interview with a former leading figure of the ANM and a close friend of Nayif Hawatmah.

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It should be borne in mind that while Habash has his idiosyncracies, PFLP decision making is closely tied to political and military events in the Middle East. The series of setbacks and defeats suffered by the other PLO organizations have affected PFLP policies too. Habash is not just an intelligent political activist; he is also an astute politician who knows how to adapt to changes in political realities. This has been manifested in significant shifts in PFLP policy orientations and activities as circumstances change. (See below). The power that the leadership enjoys enables the Front to deviate from fixed ideological norms and react to situations with political flexibility, often in defiance of the public and party mood.

THE DOMINANT CLIQUE

The Politburo of the PFLP has been dominated by a small inner circle that has been crucial in policy making. The nature and composition of the clique itself have been affected by the changing political scene. When the Front first emerged, the leadership was divided into conflicting factions. The struggle between the factions was intense. Membership loyalty was divided roughly among three leaders: Habash (along with his intimate associate Wadi' Haddad), Hawatmah and Ahmad Jibril. As noted earlier, the rivalries among the three tore the organization apart and led to the creation of two more organizations from the fabric of the original. The situation became relatively more stable after the departure of the "trouble makers" and Habash was able to keep the remaining members and the Politburo relatively united and monolithic as the organization passed through a fateful crisis during the Central Committee meeting of November 5, 1971, when it was decided to halt all airplane hijackings.[18] The leadership had feared that Wadi' Haddad, who was an influential Politburo member and a close friend of Habash, would break away, taking with him important military cadres, in a move similar to that made by Ahmad Jibril in 1968. (Although Haddad did in fact defect from the Front in 1972 and continued to launch "international" military operations, i.e. acts of random violence, his group was small in number. More importantly, Haddad had always been a close friend and a loyal supporter of Habash. Lacking the sophisticated intellectual qualities of his former classmate, Haddad trusted the political leadership of Habash. Long after his defection, Haddad maintained secret channels of communications with Habash and some leading PFLP figures. It is said that Haddad left large sums of money, which he had gained through spectacular international operations, to the PFLP upon his mysterious death in early 1978).[19] Habash was able to rally the Committee and the whole Party behind

18. For more information on the crucial meeting, see Habash's account in *al-Hadaf*, March 18, 1972.

19. The information on Haddad's organization is based upon a series of conversations with members of the organization, Beirut, 1982.

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him, after denouncing airplane hijacking, by depicting international operations as mere manifestations of petit-bourgeois spirit and adventurism.

When the war broke out in Lebanon in 1975, the PFLP was dominated by Bassam Abu Sharif, who was both the official spokesman and editor of *al-Hadaf,* Taysir Qubba'ah, head of the International Department, Abu Ahmad Yunis, a PFLP specialist on Lebanese affairs, and Abu Mahir al-Yamani, who was responsible for the PFLP's relationship with the PLO. But there was always a tug-of-war between this group and that of Politburo member Abu Ali Mustafa. The members of the Abu Sharif group were on fairly good terms with the Fatḥ leadership, and with Arafat personally, before and after the PFLP returned to the PLO Executive Committee in 1977. Abu Sharif and his comrades have never been reputed to be fascinated with the notion of "armed struggle" and they have called for close coordination between the PFLP and Fatḥ. Today, they are in a very weak position; they represent a minority voice within the PFLP leadership that seeks an accommodation with Arafat. It is worth noting that this faction emerged when the Front had very close ties with the Iraqi regime. Thus, in 1977 Abu Sharif refused to publish in *al-Hadaf* a speech by Abu Ali Mustafa in which the latter vehemently condemned Iraqi policies. As the Front's alliances change, so the dominance of leading cliques change, the latter being a function of the former. As the Arabic proverb says, *"likulli zamanin dawlatun wa rijal"* (Each era has its own state and its own men).

The Abu Sharif faction lost its power with the unfolding of a new phase of PFLP alliances following the last Party congress in 1981. The faction, with the exception of Abu Mahir al-Yamani, was strongly attacked for lavish lifestyles. It was also assailed for its non-involvement in military activities. The congress then witnessed a mini *intifadah* (uprising), similar to the Fatḥ uprising of May 1983, and the members of the Abu Sharif faction were removed from their influential policy making posts. The sweeping changes coincided with Habash's diminishing role as a result of his ailment. Abu Sharif was removed from his important positions as an official spokesman and the editor of *al-Hadaf;* his rank was also lowered from that of Politburo member to that of Central Committee member. Qubba'ah was also lowered from the Politburo to Central Committee membership. He was also ousted as head of the International Department. As for Abu Ahmad Yunis, he was executed some months prior to the convening of the congress after he was convicted by a special Party tribunal of embezzlement, fraud and several murders. The events of the case were never revealed, not even to Party members.[20]

Clearly, the case of Abu Ahmad Yunis calls into question the conduct and structures of the Party which allowed such a person to reach the Politburo. The case embarrasses the Front which has always emphasized that it sharply differs

20. Information on the case of Abu Ahmad Yunis based upon a series of conversations in Beirut in August 1984 with a high ranking PFLP military officer who interrogated Yunis before his execution.

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from Fatḥ in terms of the conduct of its leaders. Indeed, the stubborn facts of the case, along with the conduct of PFLP in Lebanon in the past decade, have erased those differences that used to distinguish it from other PLO organizations, especially Fatḥ. The legitimacy of the Front, and its very foundations, rested on the claim that it was different and distinctive. It was its source of pride and attraction to all those members from other organizations who used to be disenchanted with the corruption and misconduct they encountered in their own groups.

When the new clique took over in 1981, the power base of the old clique was quickly eliminated. The new group centers around Abu Ali Mustafa, deputy secretary-general, and Abu Ahmad Fuad, head of the Military Department, which administers all PFLP training camps, plans military operations, and commands all PFLP fighters. The new clique is known to have close ties with Syria and Libya, the closest allies of the PFLP today. Abu Ali Mustafa always resented the Front's past alliance with Iraq, which lasted from the early seventies until 1978. The political orientation of the new clique is consistent with Syrian policy and reflects the influence that Syria has in the PFLP leadership, which decreases Habash's political independence. Habash was pressured to go along with the Mustafa clique with respect to supporting the Fatḥ *intifadah* movement against Arafat, although it was known among PFLP members that Habash was originally hostile to the uprising, which he considered an undesirable defection. (He was said by friends and critics alike to suffer from the "defection syndrome"[21] because he fears defections himself.)

The PFLP's diverse views toward the Fatḥ uprising were clearly demonstrated by its hesitant and undecisive stance towards the Arafat leadership. The strong Habash of yesterday would have forced the Mustafa faction to split from the PFLP, and his coexistence with it today is a sign of his growing weakness. The Mustafa faction refuses to reconcile with Fatḥ and was against the signing of the Aden-Algiers agreement in 1984, which was intended to forgive Arafat for his rapprochement with Egypt and Jordan and for which Habash lobbied very hard inside the organization and over which he is said to have threatened to retire from politics altogether. On the other hand, the Abu Sharif faction, which still exists within the Central Committee, is pushing towards a more moderate line towards Fatḥ. It is also trying to pull the Front away from the Syrian sphere of influence.

The war between the two factions would have torn the PFLP asunder were it not for Habash's efforts and the obedience to him by the Abu Sharif faction. The tension, however, led a small faction within the PFLP, with some followers in Syria and Lebanon, to split in late 1984 and form an independent organization under the name of *Al-Rifaq wa al-Kawadir fi al-Jabhah al-Sha'biyyah li Tahrir Filastin* (the Comrades and Cadres of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine). This small new organization has rejected the "hesitant and compro-

21. Muhsin, Hashim Ali, *Al-Intifadah: Thawrah Hatta al-Nasr* (The Uprising: Revolution Until Victory), Damascus, 1983, pp. 163–164.

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mising" position of Habash, whom it accused of collaborating with the "Palestinian Right."[22] The emergence of the new organization has been interpreted as a Syrian signal to Habash, a warning that he should comply with Syria's uncompromising position towards Arafat if he wants to preserve the unity of his organization.

What adds to the organizational crisis is that the Mustafa faction does not have unanimous support among those members who are not Abu Sharif partisans. *Al-Hadaf,* for example, is still controlled by former members of the Palestinian Communist Workers' Party (a small and highly secretive Palestinian organization established in the late seventies by former members of Palestinian radical groups whose antagonism to the Palestinian left was greater than their opposition to Fatḥ), who also urge reconciliation with Arafat. This faction also includes some key military cadres who defected from the PFLP in the early seventies. Although this faction is in disagreement with the Mustafa faction, it does not have good relations with Abu Sharif either.

THE BUREAUCRACY AS A PRESSURE GROUP

Ironically enough, the flow of oil money reached, and eventually corrupted, this most "revolutionary" of Arab communist Parties. In the early seventies, Layla Khalid, who became famous for participating in airplane hijackings, and other leading PFLP members were on a fundraising effort in the United Arab Emirates. The group was entertained by Shaykh Zayid bin Sultan, who donated one million pounds sterling[23] and a new page was opened in PFLP history. The old "revolutionary" and "principled" commitment to reject government money suddenly became "unnecessary intransigence." Revolutionary purity is only indicative of petit-bourgeois idealism, the PFLP preached to its members. An exorbitant price was paid in return for that money; the cost was political. The money left a profound impact on the political position, as well as on the internal organizational formation of the PFLP. It created, and then consolidated, a bureaucracy within the organization. Most of the oil money, including generous Libyan donations, reached the PFLP indirectly through PLO institutions in which it is represented. This has left the PFLP with substantial wealth, (uncomparable, of course, to the wealth of Fatḥ), which was invested in numerous profitable financial ventures. Gradually, the PFLP became overly secretive about its

22. For the views of the new organization, see their pamphlet, The Comrades and Cadres of the PFLP, *Risalah ila al-Rifaq fi al-Jabhah al-Sha'biyyah li Tahrir Filastin* (A Letter to the Comrades of the PFLP), unplaced and undated (1984).

23. The event was detailed by a leading member who resigned from the PFLP in protest and published a pamphlet on the issue—Mahmud Samman's *Al-Fadihah* (The Scandal), unplaced and undated. When asked about Samman in 1984, a PFLP Politburo member told the author that they believed he was recruited by the KGB while on a training mission in Moscow.

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finances, in contrast to the early "idealistic" years, when the first page of *al-Hadaf* used to list, and in detail, all sources of income, including small contributions of food from Lebanese and Palestinian families.[24] As a result of the pouring in of money, a strong organizational (functional) and military bureaucracy was developed, and it became dependent on a continuous supply of arms and money. The abundance of both introduced the new organizational phenomenon of *al-mutafarrigh* (a full time party member or, literally, the devotee). In the past, party members were obliged to be committed activists; membership in the Front meant continuous personal sacrifices. Today, the notion of *al-mutafarrigh* implies that salaried party status is the highest stage of political commitment. Thus, it is no longer sufficient to be an active party member and have another job. Party membership has become a full-time occupation, and a well paid one at that. A full-time party member receives a salary in addition to other benefits, depending on organizational rank. Formerly, political activism was synonymous with a dedication which only a few were able to bear and endure. Today, to be a *munadil* (struggler) is to be privileged.

The growth of the new bureaucratic elite, the same new class described by Djilas, led to two major and separate divisions. The first bifurcation split the leading elite into two groups: military and administrative. The second division separated this privileged elite from the entire body of rank-and-file members. The elite became more aloof from the ordinary member. The second schism entailed a division of labor too. The leadership was confined to theoretical and staff work, while the full-time party members were involved in manual and military labor; the leadership never assumed regular combat responsibilities. "Professionals" were doing the actual fighting, and they were doing the dying too. Gone was the old "revolutionary" slogan, "every combatant is a party member and every member is a combatant."[25] The emergence of a powerful bureaucracy had a conservative influence on PFLP policies. To maintain the Lebanese base at all costs became a paramount concern, but it was not so much a concern to maintain the base as such, as it was to maintain the status quo.

The division of roles between the elite and the main membership also reflects a change in military philosophy and doctrine. The new military elite renounced the old strategy of a people's war of liberation and guerrilla warfare and adopted a more conservative and conventional view of military strategy. In the past, the PFLP viewed guerrilla warfare as the only appropriate method for the liberation of Palestine and had argued that the technological and military superiority of the enemy could only be overcome by putting into practice guerrilla warfare and a

24. See for example, *al-Hadaf*, January 1970.

25. PFLP, *The Political Report of the Second National Congress: A Strategy for the Liberation of Palestine*, (Beirut: PFLP Publications, 1969) p. 116.

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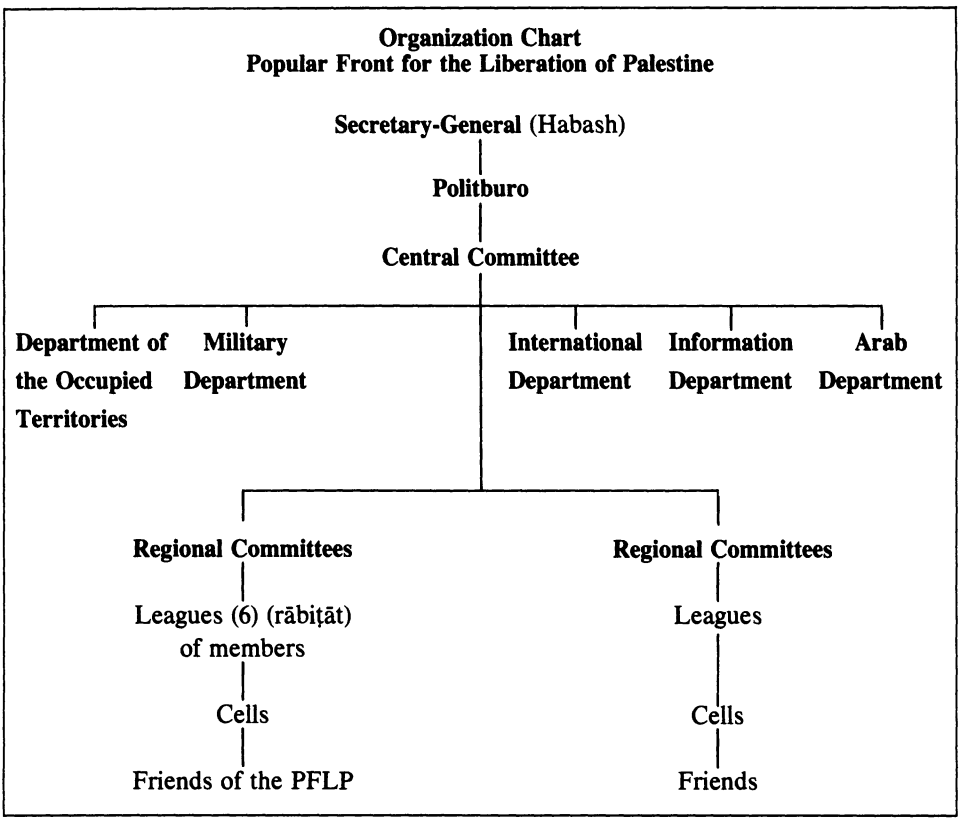

popular liberation war.[26] In a radical shift in military policy, the report of the last national congress of the PFLP which convened in 1981, maintained that guerrilla warfare is inappropriate because Palestinian lands "lack high mountains and deep rivers."[27] Consistent with that new perception, which tends to sound close to the Soviet line, the PFLP founded in 1978 a military academy to train military officers in conventional warfare. The training laid special emphasis on heavy weaponry.[28] Behind the drive to field quasi-conventional forces was a need to do something about the diminishing credibility and legitimacy of the organization in the eyes of the Palestinian in the street. It had to maintain forces in Lebanon in order to prove its willingness and readiness to fight Israel. And to relate the realm of militarism to the realm of politics, it should be noted that the military elite insisted on having exceptionally good relations with Syria in order to safeguard the lines of

26. See *ibid,* p. 73; and PFLP, *Tasks . . .*, pp. 62–65.

27. PFLP, *Al-Taqrir al-Siyasi al-Sadir 'an al-Mu'tamar al-Watani al-Rabi'* (The Political Report of the Fourth National Congress), Beirut, 1981, p. 293.

28. PFLP, the Military Department, *Barnamaj al-Tadrib al-'Askari* (The Program for Military Training), Beirut, 1981.

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communication and supply to Syrian-controlled territories in Lebanon, where most of the PFLP military bases are located.

How are Changes in Foreign Policy Orientations Justified? Tactics versus Strategy, Primary and Secondary Contradictions

In a situation of unpredictable policy shifts, the need for a stable ideological rationalization arises. The language used is of utmost importance. It should appeal across the board to party members, supporters, sophisticated intellectuals, and the general public. The need for such a doctrine increases with the lack of internal public debate and democratic decision making. The Front has utilized a loose and flexible doctrine by which changes can be justified easily and the concept of strategy-versus-tactics has become a central part of party ideological indoctrination.[29] Under this doctrine, changes in foreign policy orientations of the Front are considered to be "tactical" and designed to serve the ultimate strategy of the organization.

The task of assessing the applicability of the concept and the desirability of policy changes is left to the leadership. For instance, the new alliance with the Syrian regime in 1977, following the bloody battles in 1976 between the Syrian army and the "Joint Forces," which included the PFLP, in Lebanon, was highly repugnant to Front members and the leadership had to justify the policy shift as a mere tactic in the interest of the overall strategy of liberation. The Maoist mobile vision of the dialectical correlation between primary and secondary contradictions is an integral part of the aforementioned doctrine. Thus, in a rather mechanistic and automatic fashion, the contradiction with Syria became secondary in 1977, while the contradiction with the Iraqi regime started to increase to become a primary one in the early eighties.

A basic ideological manual of the Front issued in 1972 incorporated these ideological techniques with respect to relationships with "petit-bourgeois regimes" in the Arab world. The relationships with these regimes, the so-called "Arab Nationalist" ones, was described as being governed by a law of "conflict and alliance." The law adjusts to changing conditions by fluctuating between two opposite extremes of alliance and conflict depending on the foreign policy orientation of the Front.[30] The Law was ambiguously worded and vaguely stated to serve the purpose behind it.

The Burden of the Political Base

The implications and the constraints of the base where the PFLP leadership is physically located are far reaching. The first phase of PFLP's attempt at the

29. See Salih, Sa'd, *Fi al-Istratijiyyah wa al-Taktik al-Thawriyyayn* (On Revolutionary Tactics and Strategy), Beirut, 1979.

30. PFLP, *Tasks . . .*, pp. 27–28.

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construction of a political base started in Amman with the emergence of the Front and ended with the massacres of 1970–71. The PFLP and the Palestinian left in general were expecting the fall of the Hashemite kingdom. The toppling of Hussein was a primary objective for the Front and the political report of the second congress of the PFLP in 1969 stated the "necessity of laying strategic emphasis on the [Arab Hanoi] motto as a revolutionary principle creating coalescence between the Palestinian Revolution and the Arab revolution."[31] As is known, the battle against the Jordanian regime by the Palestinian resistance movement was lost and led to a rise of Jordanian national feeling among the population. "The artificial creation of colonialism," as the Hashemite regime is known among Arab leftists, survived the threat and was successful in rallying the public, including the Palestinian bourgeoisie in Jordan, behind Hussein.

In Lebanon, as was said earlier, the attitude was a status quo one. The PFLP bureaucracy was concerned with preserving its material interests. The PFLP ceased calling for an "Arab Hanoi"; the slogan was only declared and chanted when the bureaucratic elite was in an embryonic stage. As "revolutionary" thought and practice dominated the oratory and rhetorics, a more conservative tendency, a pragmatic and moderate one, to use the terminology of Walid Khalidi,[32] prevailed in reality. The PFLP's experience in Lebanon was far from peaceful and uninterrupted; it included facing continuous Israeli raids, confrontations with Lebanese parties hostile to the Palestinian presence in Lebanon, the Israeli invasions of 1978 and 1982, which led to the humiliating evacuation of PLO forces from parts of Lebanon, and the subsequent clashes with Shia militias in 1985, 1986 and 1987. Moreover, and for reasons beyond the scope of this article, the PLO's conduct and performance in Lebanon turned many Lebanese Muslims against the Palestinian Revolution.[33] The ferocity of the war of the camps between Shia and Palestinians illustrate the changing public attitudes among Lebanese towards the Palestinian resistance movement.

The Syrian base, from which the PFLP operates today, decreased the already limited political independence in decision making that the PFLP had retained. The PFLP was faced with a dilemma—it had to choose between stationing itself in a remote Arab capital, like Aden, and the present situation where Syrian desires and will are often dictated to it. The situation gives Syria more power to dominate factions within the PFLP itself, or to play Palestinian organizations against each other.

CONCLUSION: FLUCTUATIONS IN POLICY ORIENTATIONS

It is difficult to tell whether a change in the Arab circle of alliances determines the composition and orientations of the dominant clique of the PFLP at a given

31. PFLP, *A Strategy . . .*, pp. 46–47.

32. Khalidi, Walid, "Thinking the Unthinkable: A Sovereign Palestinian State," *Foreign Affairs*, July 1978, p. 703.

33. AbuKhalil, As'ad, "Druze, Sunni and Shi'ite Political Leadership in Present-day Lebanon," *Arab Studies Quarterly*, Fall 1985, p. 47.

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time, or whether the rise of the clique itself determines the nature of the alliances. It is fair to assume that the pressures of regional political and military events do produce internal organizational repercussions. In a movement like the Palestinian resistance movement, where the major consuming task is the struggle for survival, an organization such as the PFLP must be flexible enough to contain and digest the permanent threat of its Israeli and Arab enemies. Inability to adapt to the changing political realities, including the Arab governments' amazing foreign policy fluctuations, can cost the organization its very existence. The inclinations of the dominant clique may render the policies of the Front subject to pressures and influences from this or that Arab regime, but it has to be further examined whether the choice between subordination to Arab governments and extermination is real, or whether the choice is concocted in order to justify the inability of the leadership to go underground and create an authentic revolutionary organization which does not live at the mercy of the whims of various Arab capitals. Is compromising the professed ideological doctrine of a "revolutionary" organization and the loss of its independent will the only price for survival? It could be argued that the original defect lies in the organizational structure of the PFLP as an ostensibly revolutionary party. With the unwillingness of the leadership to dismantle the corrupt bureaucracy, and in the absence of democratic freedoms and collective leadership, the major policies and alliances of the Front will continue to be determined by Arab governments and the outcomes of factional feuds.

PFLP policy orientations have changed and shifted dramatically over the years. They transformed the organization from a "revolutionary" militant party, a reputation it still wrongly has, into one of the more moderate and conservative elements of the PLO. George Habash now bitterly complains about Palestinian extremist organizations and regards them as detrimental to the Palestinian national interest.[34] Contrary to claims constantly made in the West, most PLO organizations are willing to confine their national aspirations to any part (within limits, of course) of historic Palestine presented to them.

On the international level, the PFLP first advocated the Maoist ideological line, along with Chinese foreign policy, and was fairly critical of the Soviet attitudes towards the settlement of the Arab-Israeli conflict.[35] The major ideological manual of the PFLP, *A Strategy for the Liberation of Palestine,* is a Palestinian version, sometimes word for word, of Mao's *Analysis of the Classes in Chinese Society*. The Front established official links with the Chinese government when Habash headed a PFLP delegation to China and North Korea in 1970.[36] China, however, condemned the hijacking operations and considered them

34. See Habash's lengthy interview with the Kuwaiti newspaper, *al-Qabas,* February 18, 1987.
35. For a sample of the criticisms, see Habash's interview in *Life, op.cit.;* and PFLP, A Strategy . . ., p. 57 and p. 79.
36. See *al-Hadaf,* October 17, 1970.

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harmful to the war of national liberation.[37] The Chinese stopped their military aid to the PFLP in favor of Fatḥ, although the PFLP officially renounced hijacking late in 1971. The PFLP turned then to Moscow, and has since become the loyal ally and client of the USSR. The report of the last congress of the Party in 1981 praised Soviet policy highly and avoided mentioning any reservations they might have about that policy. In return, the USSR supplies the PFLP with military aid and receives a number of PFLP members for military and political training.[38]

The PFLP has renounced its past policy of "striking at imperialist interests" in the Middle East region. The PFLP used to consider this policy a major task in the path of the liberation of Palestine. This has coincided with more open and formal relationships the Front started to have with a number of Arab and non-Arab governments. The PFLP sought to gain more official recognition in accordance with an open-door policy to dispel its image as a "terrorist organization." The aforementioned meeting with Zayid bin Sultan and Habash's recent rapprochement with the Kuwaiti government in 1985[39] are two relevant examples in this respect. The formerly emphasized contradiction with "reactionary" Arab governments is now downplayed in the literature. The enmity is restricted to the "imperialist-Zionist enemy"[40]; and contrary to what Fouad Ajami has maintained,[41] the PFLP has never included the "petit-bourgeois regimes" in the camp of its enemies.

On the Palestinian level, the change has been more noticeable and more significant. As was said earlier, the last congress dismissed guerrilla warfare as an inappropriate method of liberation for purely geographical reasons. What is more surprising in this respect is that the PFLP accepted in its last congress, and for the first time in its history, the PLO's transitional program of 1974, which had originally caused the PFLP to suspend its membership in the PLO Executive Committee from 1974 until 1977, when the PFLP initiated under Iraqi auspices the now-defunct Rejectionist Front. The PFLP now accepts the two-state solution, contrary to its past insistence on a secular solution in the whole of Palestine. The political report of the Fourth Congress only denounced the "Palestinian-Jordanian state,"[42] while it specifically adopted the "transitional solution."[43] The differences on this issue between the various Palestinian organizations have narrowed to a minimum, but the raison d'etre of the PFLP has always rested in its distinctiveness. That this new moderation will ultimately lead into a serious crisis within the organization seems highly likely.

37. *Al-Nahar*, November 21, 1971.
38. An interview with a PFLP high-ranking military officer, Beirut, 1984.
39. On Habash's meeting with the Emir of Kuwait, see *al-Hadaf*, June 17, 1985.
40. See the interview with Abu Ali Mustafa in *al-Shira'*, January 10, 1984.
41. Ajami, Fuad, *The Arab Predicament*, (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1978), p. 143.
42. PFLP, (Political Report of the Fourth National Congress), *op.cit.*, pp. 211–213.
43. *Ibid*, p. 234.

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